capitulated to a long-standing demand to declare the Ahmadiyas a non-Muslim minority.[3] The issue was intensified under Zia with the blasphemy law (especially Article 295-C) that brought in the death penalty or life imprisonment for blasphemy against the Prophet and effectively put every Ahmadiya at risk by simply practising his or her religion.

More prominent however has been the conflict between Sunnis and Shi'as that increased particularly after General Zia-ul-Haq took over as the chief martial law administrator in 1977, declaring that the Islamic society for which Pakistan had been created would be established and enforcing a Sunni Islam across the country. Zia's Islamization programme was in contrast to popular practice in the culture, in which most people were 'personally' but not 'publicly' religious. An unexpected outcome was that by relying on a policy grounded in Sunni Islam, the state fomented factionalism: by legislating what was Islamic and what was not, Islam itself could no longer provide unity because it was then being defined to exclude previously included groups. This had a particular repercussion in Shi'a–Sunni sectarian disputes as people started to ask 'Who is *really* a Muslim?' – a question that has increasingly haunted all Pakistanis since Zia started narrowing what defined a Muslim.

The fact that Islam could mean different things to different communities is at the bottom of Pakistan's sectarian problems. That Pakistan professed to be an Islamic state meant that Islamic laws would not merely be observed but that the state would enforce them. Which school of Islamic law would hold sway, and how that would affect those who did not recognize its authority, was not taken into account.

The army versus the rest – Pakistan through the prism of democracy

Mohammed Ali Jinnah wanted Pakistan to be a constitutional, parliamentary democracy informed by Muslim values. Yet after independence power was concentrated in the hands of the elite, with Jinnah as the governor general, president of the Muslim League and head of the Constituent Assembly; this created an unfortunate situation when he died thirteen months later because there was no one to fill his shoes.

The army became involved in domestic politics early on, inexorably changing the nature of the Pakistani state. After independence Pakistan suffered from three long periods of army rule starting with General Ayub Khan in 1958, when the parliamentary system came to an end for the first time. He handed over power to General Muhammad Yahya Khan in 1969 who oversaw the 1970 elections